

Purpose of the interview

[0. Intro]

Thanks for making the time. We're a student team researching international business communication, specifically what happens when language gets in the way. There are no right or wrong answers. We're trying to understand your actual experience, so please be as candid as possible.

domande per intervista

1. Can you briefly describe your role and the nature of your work?
2. How often do you have meetings with people who speak a different language? (Weekly / monthly / occasionally)
3. Are these mostly one-on-one or group meetings?
4. Do you feel there's a language barrier? And is it complicating the way of doing business?
5. What do you currently do to solve the problem? (*Nothing / use captions / use an interpreter / speak in a shared language*)
6. If you use any translation tools, which ones? Why that one specifically?
7. How satisfied are you with what you're using now? What would you say is the biggest limitation?
8. Imagine the translation came through as audio — like a live interpreter in your ear — instead of text on screen. Would that change anything for you?
 - (*If yes*): What specifically would be different?
 - (*If no*): What would actually help?
9. Is this something you'd want your company to pay for? What would make it worth it?
 - (*If yes*): What's a price range that feels reasonable per meeting / per month?

PROFESSOR MAIN POINT TO TAKE INTO CONSIDERATION

Good structure: clear target (SMBs scaling globally in technical niches) and a real pain (translation that fails in specialized contexts). Two fixes: give the product a name, and tighten the need into one concrete job (eg, close sales and run technical meetings without miscommunication). Pick one main alternative (eg, human interpreters, or a specific live-translation tool) and make your differentiation testable: what accuracy you expect on domain terms, latency during calls, and what "one-time customization" includes (setup time, cost, who builds language packs). In customer interviews, map the **highest-stakes moments/needs** (sales calls, support escalations,

compliance docs), what they do today, and what an error costs them. Also test **willingness to pay and who owns this budget** (Sales, Support, Ops).

Interview #1 - CISO at Royal Solutions Group

Transcript

Interviewer: For starters, would you be willing to briefly describe the role and nature of your work?

CISO: Uh, yeah, I mean, for work right now, I wear a bunch of different hats. One of them is the CISO of Royal. So that's in charge of security, or technical security. I also do migrations. I do analytics. And then I wear a hat as a fractional CISO. So I work for different radiology groups that need a CISO, but they don't have enough funds to pay for one all the time. So those are the things I do, but related to what you're working on, I told your mom that I've done things like, uh, I helped a company build an AI product, and the main, one of the founders was in Spain. And he originally was from Brazil and so I had a little bit of trouble understanding him. So I would turn on closed captions and things when we were doing video calls so that I could make sure I understood it. I'm also hard of hearing, so, um, so that helped with that also. And then I've done work with people in India, and most often we used WhatsApp to communicate.

Interviewer: And are these meetings usually like one-on-one or group meetings?

Matt Dewey: The meetings with the guy in Spain, it was normally 3 of us, so it was 2 of the founders and me. When I was working with people in India, most of the time, that was one on one. So I was, uh, I was the chief technical resource, and I would work with the operations person that was in India. actually making things happen.

Interviewer: Do you feel like the language barrier complicated the way of doing business between you guys?

Matt Dewey: Sometimes there was jargon, um, so that would be hard. Jargon doesn't always translate well between, you know, even in the same industry, it doesn't always translate well between different countries. Challenges also are not always understood well. So that has trouble with communication. Um, And then for me, it was hard because sometimes I couldn't understand that with an accent, right?

Interviewer: Yeah, for sure.

Matt Dewey: So, you know, if you can't hear well, accents are even harder.

Interviewer: So then, when you're talking with these people, do they usually speak in their language and you use a translation device, or is it they're speaking more English to you?

CISO: Yes. Most people's English, yeah, um, it was interesting. I went to a trade show once with one of the my Indian colleagues, and we were talking to another person from India, and they spoke in English, and they were talking about things that were technical. And I said, you know, if it helps, you guys can talk whatever language you want. Yeah. It won't matter to me. And they said, we don't speak the same language. Um, even though they were in India. Yeah, yeah. They spoke, it wasn't just different dialects, it was actually different languages.

Interviewer: Yeah,. There's tons of languages in India! But, so you said that you used captions before when you were talking with some of these people. So, what was it a certain platform that you used? Was it just like on Zoom and you used like the built-in translation or do you know what kind of thing?

CISO: So we were using the boat, we were using Google Meet. And so it was the first one I knew that had, um, closed captions. Um, and this was this was probably 3 to 4 years ago. So Zoom didn't have it yet.

Interviewer: Oh, okay.

CISO: It was only people meet that I knew of that did.

Interviewer: Okay, so you chose that one specifically just because it was the only one you had heard of?

CISO: No, we chose because it was free. Oh, so... There's that. And as we were talking, I was like, you know, because I was struggling, and sometimes they would, the 2 founders both spoke Spanish fluently. And so if they couldn't understand me, if one of the guys couldn't understand me, they would talk in Spanish for a bit. And then they, uh, I could see he was explaining what I was saying and then, and then we all got back, then we would speak English again. But yeah, we chose Google Meat because it was free. They were a start.

Interviewer: Fair enough! So, how satisfied are you with Google Meets translation device? Would you say that there's a lot of limitations and errors with the product or would you say that it works pretty smoothly?

CISO: Well, it was just doing closed captioning, right? Because they were speaking English to me. Um, It did a, it did a fair job. The only time that it really struggled was, and again, this was 4 years ago, I'm sure it's changed since now, since then. I know Zoom is much better and, I mean, Zoom didn't exist then and it's pretty good now. And teams is quite good. I run the transcription all the time. The only time that Google Meet back then had trouble was when it had to, it had to

make changes because of context. Right? So as the sentence was running on, it was trying to figure out and predict what was what was being said. And sometimes it would go, oh, I got the context wrong. And then it would rewrite the sentence. But it wasn't often. I would think in the languages like Spanish, to English, it would have trouble because of the way verbs are. Right? And so Spanish is written in reverse. spoken in reverse of our English is for many of the transmissions.

Interviewer: Yeah. During these meetings, do you usually discuss a lot of high stakes topics, or is, like, are you ever worried about the security, I guess, of the captioning platform?

CISO: No, um... No, I wasn't worried about the security of the platform. The, Because we weren't, if anybody had gotten, if anybody got the transcripts, it wouldn't. It wouldn't be giving away any IP. It was more blue sky. Right? Um, not a lot that was concrete in it. And then, um, trying to get ideas of where the platform should go, how we, how we should get somewhere. And conversations like this, right? where they were trying to get information from me on where their product might want to go. But it was it was more blue sky.

Interviewer: Okay. Awesome. And then my next question is actually more about the audio aspect. Um, but you said that you struggle with your hearing. Is it in both ears?

CISO: Yes.

Interviewer: Yeah, my stepdad also has a similar issue. Would you be able to hear if it was in an audio in your ear? Or would that be something that you'd be interested in?

CISO: So, I don't normally wear, um, I'm, like, if I'm gonna listen to music, I either listen it to it directly on my hearing aids, or I wear, um, you know, over the ear that work with my hearing aids. Um, I, I've never bought a pair of, um, like AirPods because that's not going to work for me, right? Well, now they do because they, you could use them to function as hearing aids. Yeah. But previous versions, I haven't, and I have actual hearing aids. So that, you know, so I haven't switched over to them yet.

Interviewer: So if there was a translation device that did have an over-the-ear sort of, you know, system, would that be something that you would be interested in or you feel would make the translation smoother?

CISO: Yeah, I would do that. The one thing that's really important for, um, over-the-ear headphones and somebody that wears hearing aids, if it's not all over-the-ear headphones it won't work with hearing aids. Sometimes they'll cause feedback. And so all you hear is whistling. Um, so I've got many pairs of headphones and some of them I can't wear with my

hearing aids. It seems to depend on how the speaker is. if it'll work like this. So I've got like, I've got a pair of both, uh, acoustic, um, uh, acoustic mass here, um, over that, over the year headphones, and they work fine. But I've got a pair of um, high-end Senhauser that don't. And I've got a pair of fillips that also don't. So I have to take my hearing aids out when I'm going to listen to music with those. So it would have to, you would have to pay attention. And I don't know. I've only had a few hearing aids, right? I've only had three or four pair. Yeah. So it's not a good sampling if that is a problem that everybody has or only the pairs I've had.

Interviewer: So, but if we could create a product that, you know, would work for you and had, like, the over-the-ear sort of concept, would this be something you'd want your company to pay for? Like, what kind of things would make it worth it for you?

CISO: Well, so if it was at the right price point, you know, if I'm traveling myself overseas, I would want to have it, right? I could, at that point, understand everybody I'm talking to. Um, But the one challenge you're gonna have is that now the iPhone could do it, right?

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah.

CISO: So, you know, your price point would have to be at a place that competes with that and the ubiquity that that has. What, like, hypothetically, doesn't need to be super exact, but what would around the right price point be for you specifically in your company? So for me, probably 100 bucks. I would think. You know, if I was, because I don't do a lot of business that's outside of the US. But, It might make sense if you were able to make this work with, say, a job or headset so that people could talk to, um, you know, because we have a lot of people, uh, in our concierge staff that they can talk to people of different languages. And they were those Jabra headsets all day long, right? And if it could work along with that, that would or replace the Jabra, but I don't know if you know how good Jabra is. They're fantastic. very comfortable headset that people can wear all day long. You know? Um, and, uh, so you would have to compete with them, uh, if you could instead build your stuff to go along with them. That might be more valuable. Or to be in line. with the jobber headset. Yeah. That, that might be too.

Interviewer: Um, and then by \$100, you meant a monthly, monthly subscription fee or like yearly or just like one time.

CISO: So I was thinking one time, okay. If you if you have to, if you're going through a model or something like that, well then you have to, you'd have to have some sort of subscription. Yeah, right? to make it work. So it would depend on how you're doing it. If you could convince people that you have to have the model, the model can't live in a piece of hardware and it needs to be updated often enough. You know, you said, we're constantly adding languages. We're constantly adding different dialects. We're constantly adding, you know, jargon. We can speak all the

different types of jargon you ever would want. Right? So we can speak legally. We can speak what accountants speak. We can speak all these different things. And we're constantly adding, then a monthly subscription might work, but then you'd probably, I would probably say, again, for me, it wouldn't be all that much because I don't do it that often. But, uh, you know, if you think about how much dragon uh, speaking costs, right? It's monthly rate is, you know, not all that much. Again, that's somebody you would be competing with. Yeah. Right? And so you'd probably want to say, I think you probably want to be around 10 to \$15 a month. Uh, you know, that would still get you at the, you know, \$100 a year. You know, at \$10.

Francesca: Okay, so can you briefly Describe your role and the nature of the work?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: So I am the Ceo of Coverlit, a company producing coating for the packaging industry. Since it is a small company, I'm actually also the sales manager, the purchasing manager and the financial manager.

Francesca: How often do you have meetings with people who speak a different language?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Well, I mean it depends what you mean by meeting; when I have a face to face meeting, maybe this happens once or twice in a month. And if you speak about phone calls, it can be on a weekly basis.

Francesca: And do you usually do phone calls or video calls?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: No, basically phone call ectually, just sometimes it can happen that we have some some calls through like meet or other platforms.

Francesca: Are these mostly group meetings or one-to-one?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: For the most part it's one to one, but in some other cases it can be group meetings

Francesca: Do you think there is a language barrier when you' talk with your clients? And if there is, does it complicate the way you are doing business?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Well, if I am having a phone, normally it is because the other person is speaking English, or of course Italian, if it is with an Italian partner. If it is related to a visit that I have to do in another country, that could be much more difficult, because it depends on the people that have to meet. If you like top management or higher levels of management, you can find people speaking in English or French for instance, but by the time you go to production and you have to speak with technical people, that can be a nightmare, because in some places they don't speak English, but just their own language. So in that case it can be a difficult barrier.

Francesca: Ok, so it happens more when you are speaking face to face with someone rather than during calls or video calls.

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Well, in some cases I try to learn, let's say a little bit of their language; for example if we are speaking about Spanish. So when it comes to South American or Mexican companies, where they speak Spanish, I try to teach myself how to manage those kinds of

conversations. Otherwise when you go into other countries, you need a translator, but even in that case it's **not that easy**.

Francesca: Okay. So when you said that you had to learn Spanish to speak with our clients, Do you think that speaking Spanish was time consuming or if you had to make one of your let's say, one of the people working for you to Learn Spanish, do you think it'll be costly?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Of course, I mean, it's costly, you have to invest the time in trying to learn something. To be honest, in this particular case, I speak "Espaliano", which is a sort of mix between Spanish and English, since Spanish is similar to Italian, so it is something that you can learn little by little. But of course, otherwise it is going to be very costly.

Francesca: Okay, so for the moment, the only way you are solving the problem with the language barrier is by learning the language of the clients you are speaking with or eventually you try to manage with people speaking in English, right?,

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Yes, because I mean, I try to speak Spanish, being in Italian, can be not that difficult, to at least make yourself understandable with other people. But I cannot even imagine try to speak Russian with guy from Kazakhstan or from Russia, or from other countries that cannot speak English. So in that case of course, it is going to be impossible.

Francesca: Ok, so is this a reason why you are not considering expanding in some markets that maybe you think they could be actually a business occasion.

Giangiorgio Griziotti: You know, for some kind of business, if you are not able to have a direct contact with some key persons, It's going be really difficult to install a new business because using interpreters it's not easy because your missing let's say the direct contact with the person. So, in some case I realize that going around with an interpreter it's not easy, a key solution, so I had to give up because there was no chance of communicating in the right way.

Francesca: Ok, ok. So, the only translation tool you are using this moment is just eventually in that case a human translator.

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Yeah, yeah,

Francesca; And so like the biggest limitation that you are facing, if I understood correctly, is that you don't have direct contact with the person and you cannot really create that kind of actual conversation and relationship that maybe you're searching for.

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Yeah, exactly. I mean, when it comes of it's a technical aspect and you have to convince a new customer about your products, but you don't have the possibility to

speak directly with him explaining all the benefits, even if you are using an interpreter, I realized that it's not absolutely easy. So, as I was telling you before, in some case it was impossible to install a good relation with these people that didn't speak any foreign language, so it was impossible to create a good contact for doing business with them.

Francesca: Speaking actually of the phone calls and video calls that you do, have you ever considered using a software or a platform for translating?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Not yet.

Francesca: Ok, and do you know why?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: (he laughs) No, to be honest not. I just heard about some new platforms that have just been released recently. So, as far as I knew, those kinds of tools were not available. So, I didn't know that you could install some specific tools during the video calls that could automatically translate your language in foreign language.

Francesca: Ok, so let's say that you are able to actually install a software or a platform? Would you prefer it to be from text, so for example the person is talking and you can read through subtitles what they are saying, or would you prefer to hear it from your headphones?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Of course, if you hear something it's easier than to read it with subtitles, so of course, there could be a tool that when someone is speaking in his language is automatically translated in your language, This is gonna be much easier.

Francesca: Ok, perfect. And how much would you pay for it and how would you value this possible product?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Difficult question to be honest. Not knowing what could be the market price of a tool like this one, so to say if I could spend like a 100 or 1,000 \$ in a month to be able to have this kind of tool. Sometimes, first you need to test the product, so in this case the tool and then realize if it could be wise to pay for this kind of tool.

Francesca: Okay, so, probably, if you were able to try a demo of the product to understand its value, would you consider investing in the product?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: Absolutely.

Francesca: Perfect, then I have the last question for you. Let's say that you are able to choose between a broad language translator or a more specific one. Do you think that in your industry

language technicity is crucial and so would you consider it important to have a tool that can translate more technical language or more general?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: No, this is the key point. Knowing technical language is mandatory in my business. You cannot just talk about the weather or the football matches, but something technical so that you can explain. Once you have a technical product, you have to be in the position to explain to your potential customer the benefits of your product. So you need a technical language, because he's speaking technically more or less, and you have to speak technically in order to propose to them the advantages of the product. Speaking generally is not going to be useful.

Francesca: Ok, and Have you ever had problems using that technical language in your personal like career?

Giangiorgio Griziotti: If I knew and if I met someone speaking at least in English, it would not have been an issue because of course, I got the technical language little by little about the products I'm selling. Nowadays, it is not difficult to explain myself in English rather than in French or of course in Italian and even in Espaliano about products that I'm selling. But if I need a tool that allows me to speak with a Chinese guy or Russian guy or whatever is the language of my potential customer, of course I would need a tool to translate technical language.

Francesca: Okay, perfect. Thank you for your time

Interview #3 - CFO at Royal Solutions Group

Interviewer: Can you briefly describe your role and the nature of your work?

CFO: Um, technology management. The business to business, you know, relationships selling, selling technology and implementing it.

Interviewer: Okay, awesome. Um, and how often do you have meetings with people who speak a different language?

CFO: I mean, often, but they always speak English. You know, even in my prior career, which I'm trying to use to give you better answers, but like, I meet with people that speak other languages, but English has always been a language that, you know, that they've spoken. Um, so I've had to deal more with accents and cultural accents and cultural challenges. More than needing a translator.

Interviewer: So have you ever used translators in these business meetings or no?

CFO: No, I haven't had to use translators. I think most of my career have been like business to business. And if the company is in more of like a BDC where, like, they're selling to consumers, to individuals, I can see that, you know, potentially, you know, needing more of a translation layer. Like even, like, in my industry now, right? The patients are using on technology. And we have to, we have to translate to technology because the patients come in and, but I've just found that in business, even across the world, not to negate your whole project, but in my experience, they've always spoken English. Now, there's people that, there's been, like I said, accent and cultural things that make it hard to communicate, even remotely, because you don't really understand people's body language as much. You don't understand some of the slang they might use.

Interviewer: Yeah.

CFO: Um, and so maybe that's another, you know, add on, you can put your tools, something to help, um, cultural barriers. It's not always a language barrier. You know, there's things that they say, uh, that in America means something, but they're still using English, but when they say, when the Japanese people say it, it's, like, you just misinterpreting, because, you know, the culture uses the words different. So, yeah, I don't have direct experience. Um, having to do business with someone who does things wrong, which. Mm.

Interviewer: Honestly that Narrows down the questions I might ask you.

Steve: You can still ask them I will just answer with previous experience.

Interviewer: Okay, so the next question was, what do you currently do to solve the problem? (referring to language barriers) Like using captions, an interpreter, or speaking in a shared language, like you said earlier.

CFO: They're speaking English and like, or there's some, if, if that person's English is really broken, like they'll, they'll have a, a, a translator, basically, someone is, or will have somebody on our team that's fluent in that language. So that's that would be my that would be my other answer of how we address it.

Interviewer: Okay, so you use people as translators, rather than devices?

CFO: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah, translators and interpreters, you know.

Interviewer: And are you like satisfied with those translations? Do you feel like they work well?

CFO: Um, I think if you have people, it's not as scalable, it's bottleneck, you know, you have to have somebody there. But I think I think it works well. It's just not as good as using the technology platform that did it. Um, and then there's always, like, you know, Google Translate and those tools where we've pasted in things and just used it to communicate in writing. Mm hmm. But not verbal.

Interviewer: And then, would you, like, if hypothetically there was a device that would provide those auditory translations rather than having to, like, use a person? Um, would that be something that you would ever be interested in?

CFO: Yeah. Absolutely. Um, yeah, I mean, we've, I've tried to use Google Translate, just traveling and speaking to people. So if you did it in real time, on a conference call, then, then the person can speak in their native language, because even the people I've met with, I say they speak English, but their native language is not in English, so they think in their native language. Or that they are thinking it, then they're gonna communicate better. So I think it's a great idea to have that built in.

Interview #4 - Senior Manager of Cloud Platform Engineering at Insight Enterprises, Senior Manager

Interviewer: Okay. So for starters, I'm gonna describe a little bit about the product just so you have some background. So this is for my entrepreneurship class, but we decided to make a sort of translation device that provides real time auditory translation. So like in an earpiece sort of thing through like zoom calls or teams calls or anything remote basically. And we're targeting small international companies that, that you know, communicate with a lot of different people and different languages, that sort of thing. So can you briefly describe your role and the nature of your work?

Senior Manager: Well, I am in the consulting and solutions business and I provide, I meet with a lot of clients and do a lot of sales calls and a lot of calls where I have to scope services and so people want us to do like an implementation of cloud. So I have to, I have to interview the client, scope it, figure out what they want, price it, and then do the work. Which could, which could span a month. It could span multiple months.

Interviewer: So in your role, how often do you have meetings with people who speak a different language or their native language is not English?

Senior Manager: Not many, but we do deal with, we do have a Canada office and we do have Quebec customers that are French first. Something like that would help not only for that type of call, but if we do customer service calls with Quebec first. French speaking customers, Something like that, like a support call. Having an earbud like that would allow us to not have to hire French speaking people. It would actually translate for us.

Interviewer: So are these meetings that you have usually one on one or group meetings?

Senior Manager: Usually group. Okay, well it's, it's, it's a teams meeting with multiple people. I would be multiple people through a teams or zoom or whatever. Yeah, any, any type of insert conferencing system here.

Interviewer: So do you feel like there's a language barrier that complicates like the way of doing business between you guys?

Senior Manager: I think it limits our market because we mostly work with US speaking customers. Well, yeah, but like it may expand our market and allow us to speak to other countries and do business with them.

Interviewer: So. But when you're like communicating with these people from Quebec, do you feel like there's a big language barrier between you guys?

Senior Manager Oh, yeah, yeah, I, I would. In order to do business with that country, I'd have to hire French speaking people, which is hard to do. So if I had a nearby that translated for me, then I wouldn't, I could use US speaking or English speaking people to. And it would just translate for me. So yes, I could take support calls from Quebec customers.

Interviewer: So but when you're like already doing that, do you use a translation device or do they just speak in English?

Senior Manager: Most customers speak English. Yeah.

Interviewer: Okay.

Senior Manager: Yeah, yeah. I don't do, I don't do foreign speaking customers hardly at all. But it limits us, it would limit, limit our ability to do business with other countries.

Interviewer: If you had a translation that came through as an audio, like a live interpreter in your ear instead of like text on the screen, would you prefer that or would you prefer reading it?

Senior Manager: That would be nice. As long as it's accurate and quick. Yeah, and what, what I mean by quick is you know when you're using Google Translate, there's a delay between waiting for them to reply, so it depends on how real time that is. If it's not very real time, I would say having it translate on text may be faster. But if it's, if it's real time, then I would say audio. Yeah, I definitely prefer audio.

Interviewer: And what sort of things would make the product worth it other than real time translation?

Senior Manager: Yeah, I'd have to be affordable, number one, like reasonable so that, you know, I could buy multiple headsets and have it not be a huge expense. So it has to be affordable. Yeah, it has to be reliable and yes, it has to integrate with like the major conferencing systems, teams, Zoom, webex. Has to be accurate. Meaning if somebody is talking on the other end and they mumble a little bit.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Senior Manager: It would be able to pick that up and do AI or something to try to fill the gaps. Yeah, to have that translation come in clearly and. And vice versa.

Interviewer: Okay, so when you said affordable, what is affordable to you? So hypothetically, we would do a sort of subscription thing. So just like generally a ballpark of what would be reasonable.

Senior Manager: So you, you buy the hardware and then you pay a subscription for the software to do what it does.

Interviewer: Correct.

Senior Manager: Okay. I would say probably one hundred to two hundred for the headset because it had to have good audio quality and noise cancellation. And then for subscription, maybe ten to twenty bucks a user a month.

Interview Summaries

Through Interview #1 with *Matt Dewey* (CISO) at RSG, we identified issues related to willingness to pay for this product and accessibility for people with disabilities. As well as the fact that most people doing business with American companies speak English. Mr. Dewey said he would be interested in the product if the price point were extremely low (\$10/month) or over-the-ear headsets that work with his hearing aid.

Through Interview #2 → (Francesca's dad)

In Interview #3 with *CFO* (CFO) of RSG, we found that most people speak English when doing business in the U.S. or use real-person translation services. Mr. Nassif introduced the idea that cultural nuance is the largest barrier rather than language (which is not our focus:/). However, Mr. Nassif is still interested in the translation device for the sake of the people he does business with, being able to communicate in their native language.

→ Noted post interview: "I was thinking for like telehealth where they use tools to communicate remotely with patients that would be a very good application because right now they need translators. I'm not sure if any of those have that kind of tech yet."

Through Interview #4 with Senior Manager (Sr. Manager) at Insight Enterprises, we found that our device would incentivize companies that don't otherwise do much work with non-English-speaking clients to start doing so. Mr. Edwards mentioned that the criteria that are most important to him are affordability and reliability. He clarified that a subscription payment of around \$10- \$20, with the initial software price at around \$100, would be ideal.

→ Noted post interview: "On your question about value, I did say that it has to be real time, but I would suggest that the product has an option to switch to text mode and captions if there's a bad connection or they really have a thick accent or something like that."

Interview #5 - LC: CEO

F: So thank you very much for having the interview with me. Can I ask you to briefly describe your role and who you are and the nature of your work, please?

L: My name is Lorenzo Cattini. I'm CEO of a family company, Cattini and Figlio, and we are manufacturers of transmission gears and other similar precision mechanical components for the power transmission industry in the EV vehicle application. We are serving the major companies worldwide, including John Deere, the Volvo Group, and other companies of this size and importance in the market. We are a medium size enterprise, employing around probably about 250 Associates, and operating in Italy since 1950.

F: Can I ask you how often you have meetings with people who speak a different language?

L: Basically every day. In our experience, 85% of the revenues are generated outside of Italy, so every day we use foreign language skills and we need to talk with people outside Italy, so we need to speak English or other languages as well. .

F: Okay, so basically, the majority of the revenues come from international clients, so if you could not communicate with them, it would be a great problem for your business.

L: The business will be just impossible to maintain. We need to communicate, of course.

F: Do you usually have one on one meetings or is it more like group meetings that you have?

L: It depends on the scope of the meeting, we may have one to one meeting as well, we may have meetings with the different groups. Our company, compared to our customers, is small, but we normally have one group in our company and maybe two or three or even more groups because there are different functions we need to interface with. So we normally have to interface with the procurement, with the purchasing section, but also with the engineers and with the quality, and we need to talk to many people.

F: Do you usually have meetings in person or by video call?

L: After COVID, the video call has been a standard. Before, normally we had audio calls by telephone, or on the web and then we had meetings in person, and after the COVID, it's just exactly opposite. Now, we normally have video calls and only for special occasions we travel to visit customers or the customers come to visit us.

F: Do you like this new way of doing business or did you prefer to do it in person?

L: Again, It depends on how important the meetings are. If there are new orders or new studies, meeting a person is absolutely essential. You can see the people, you can shake hands with them, you can really interact directly. And this let's say, has no alternative, it is priceless, as one

famous slogan tells, it cannot be replaced with anything else. We are humans, we need to interface, we need to talk to humans, we need to watch humans in their eyes, and they need to see us as well. So, this is something that will never be replaceable, but let me say it stands for just 10% of the total meetings, even less, while 90% of meetings happening by video calls become an effective way of interacting with customers.

F: Do you feel that there's actually a language barrier sometimes in your business? And if there is, where do you find it mostly? So which kind of people, for example, with top management or with lower level staff? And eventually in which way is complicating your way of doing business?

L: I think your question is the answer itself. Of course, if you talk with a high level of executives in a company, they are normally capable of speaking reasonably well, even though there is always room for improvement; but if we go lower, on the operative level, for example machine operators, people that do not normally have the opportunity to speak a foreign language, then Of course it becomes more difficult. And then there are more barriers and sometimes these people need to be helped to be supported, by other fellows that have abundant knowledge of foreign languages. By the way, the typical language we use is English.

F: Was there a particular episode during which you had to talk with the operating part of another client or another supplier and you really struggled with let them understand your view and actually like create a sort of like relation and bond with that kind of person or client, and that could have been a problem and how did you solve it eventually? i

L: It has happened in our experience, I can certainly remember some meetings that were tough, because maybe it's just pronunciation, But if you are speaking in a certain way and you believe to speak reasonably be well, but the other counterpart, the other end of the line doesn't understand, it's real problem. Then you get frustrated, and the tension starts growing, and this is that again, this is no good for the results of the meeting. Sometimes we need to needed to to call some people in our company for help, or I had to help personally, as well as it has happened with other companies; not the customers, because they are normally very well skilled in that foreign languages, but maybe suppliers, for example, then they also needed to call for help and getting more experienced colleagues to talk on their behalf, because they really couldn't understand, or either, they couldn't express what they wished to say. Yes, sometimes it can still be a barrier in business.

F: How do you currently solve this problem? For example, remaining on the example you gave me, you could not really speak with the operating staff. Did you use, like, a person or did you use a translator, like a software? How did you manage to solve the problem?

L: During a call, using a human translator it isn't easy because you need to have a direct interaction. So for written texts, I think there are good programs that can do the job, but for speaking directly, it's difficult then you normally ask for help and you order people that you know, are better and have better knowledge in other foreign languages to join the meeting, to support.

F: So you basically just ask people at higher levels, for example managers, just to help you out. So maybe they have to stop their task for a moment because they have to help just with communicating.

L: Absolutely. Sometimes it's a necessity, even though I don't like it, because we need to focus on the quality of the result. We need to do this, yes.

F: So you have to decrease productivity and efficiency in order to actually, like, have a good quality conversation and, you know, not have any miscommunication.

L: Exactly. Good communication is paramount. Of course, we do not welcome lack of productivity, this for sure, but if it's needed, we have to do it like this, yes. Some people will need to stop what they're doing and go for help.

F: Is it something that you would like to change?. So if you were able to put on your headphones and have a software on your computer that lets you talk with another person in your foreign language, while you have the translation of what they are saying in your ears. Do you think that will solve the problem or do you still think there could be something more effective?

L: I think that this could be a great thing. It depends, of course, on the degree of efficiency. It's like what you mention, if it is like a direct translation, It could certainly help, of course. If the lower level persona didn't have sufficient language skills then, this could be an effective solution.

F: What do you think would change the most if you could actually use the software? How do you think the software could improve your business?

L: I think it's a combination. To be honest, I don't believe that this software will be able to totally replace a true foreign language, it will always be a target. But it could help getting there. I know that some people are still afraid of speaking to foreign people because maybe they underestimate their skills in foreign languages or don't feel confident in speaking with other people not in their own language. Listening, expressing their opinions and understanding and reacting to these opinions. So in the short term, this technological solution could really help. Then I believe in the long term, I think people would still need to study, because there's no replacement, there's no alternative. You still need to study and try to be as independent as possible. But in the short to medium term, this technological solution would be a great help. Some people that believe that are not fluent enough, for example, in English, they will be able to participate in video calls, with reasonably less stress and let them focus more on the outcome and goal of the meeting, which is understanding customers' problems or proposing solutions. If people still do not have enough skills in foreign language, I believe a technology solution could be a great help for that.

F: How much would you be willing to make an investment for this software? So after maybe trying the product and you see it works do you think that it would be worth it to implement it and eventually how much would you pay for this kind of technology?

L: I think the approach of our company could be not to make a case by case cost, but to make a subscription. For example, for one to three years, maybe, and for a certain number of people. They could directly access this platform and participate to video calls and meetings, and I think we will be prepared to invest some money in it, although it's not for me to imagine how much this would be, but if that falls in a reasonable field and it's a reasonable investment, I think it will be more than epic to invest in this.

F: Okay, perfect. We're actually done with the questions, so, thank you very much for the time.